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**Harmonizing Human Welfare And Intrinsic Value:
Pope Francis, Franciscan Ethos, and the Critique of Aquinas’
Hierarchical Theology in Catholic Eco-Theology**

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Abstract

This paper examines Pope Francis’ ecological vision, shaped by the Franciscan ethos, as a theological alternative to the anthropocentric legacy of Thomas Aquinas. At its core is the concept of *integral ecology*, which interweaves care for creation with justice for the poor, urging all humanity to protect both the earth and the marginalized. The paper first outlines the development of Catholic eco-theology from Paul VI to Benedict XVI, situating *Laudato si’* and *Laudate Deum* within this tradition while highlighting their distinctive affirmation of the intrinsic value of all creation. It then critiques Aquinas’ hierarchical framework, where nonhuman beings exist largely for human benefit within an ordered scale of souls — vegetative, sensitive, and rational. In contrast, Franciscan theology, articulated by St. Francis of Assisi, St. Bonaventure, and John Duns Scotus, emphasizes kinship, *pietas*, and *haecceitas* (“thisness”), recognizing every creature’s dignity and agency. These perspectives promote a vision of creation as a community bound by relationality and harmony rather than by domination. Building on this foundation, Pope Francis proposes a nuanced anthropocentrism that advances ecological ethics and human flourishing, corresponding with deep ecology’s principles of self-realization.

Introduction

Since the outset of his papacy, Pope Francis has been explicit about his deliberate choice of the name Francis, indicating St. Francis of Assisi (1181–1226) as a guiding figure for his leadership (Stephan Winter 2018). He has emphasized the central aspect of the theological and spiritual reforms initiated by St. Francis of Assisi—the strong connection between caring for God’s creatures and promoting justice for the poor—as a core element of Catholic theology (Michael S. Northcott 2016, 900). This way Pope Francis, inspired by St. Francis of Assisi, establishes a profound connection between ecological concerns and the socio-economic issues responsible for exploitation and poverty, advocating for an integral ecology that addresses the root causes of the environment-socio-economic crisis (Alexandre A. Martins 2018, 422).

In his inaugural homily as Pope, Pope Francis emphasized that Saint Francis placed the duty of protecting other people and creatures at the heart of the Christian vocation. He elucidates this obligation as safeguarding and respecting all creation and the beauty of the created world, as described in the Book of Genesis and exhibited by Saint Francis of Assisi. Additionally, it involves caring for the poorest and most marginalized people (Francis 2013).

Again, in his initial press conference on March 16, 2013, Pope Francis referenced Francis of Assisi as an exemplar, particularly concerning the Church’s ecclesiastical stance towards prioritizing the needs of the impoverished and protection of creation. He advocated for “a poor church” in his Audience to Representatives of the Communications Media (Francis 2013). Here, Pope Francis alludes to what has been more formally and fundamentally articulated through the key concept of “integral ecology” in the Encyclical *Laudato si’* (Stephan Winter 2018, 290):

I do not want to write this Encyclical without turning to that attractive and compelling figure, whose name I took as my guide and inspiration when I was elected Bishop of Rome. I believe that Saint Francis is the example par

excellence of care for the vulnerable and of an integral ecology lived out joyfully and authentically.... He was particularly concerned for God's creation and for the poor and outcast. He... lived in simplicity and in wonderful harmony with God, with others, with nature and with himself. He shows us just how inseparable the bond is between concern for nature, justice for the poor, commitment to society, and interior peace (Francis 2015, no. 10).

In light of Francis of Assisi's teaching, Pope Francis extends an invitation to every inhabitant of Earth, not exclusively for Catholics but for all humanity to participate in this project of integral ecology to salvage our shared home from degradation, regardless of their background or beliefs, as he expresses in his letter: "Now, faced as we are with global environmental deterioration, I wish to address every person living on this planet" (Ibid., no. 3).

The strong connection between the writings of St. Francis and Pope Francis is evident from the title of *Laudato si'* - the first encyclical believed to be entirely by Pope Francis. Cindy Wooden of Catholic News Service explains in her article "The Encyclical Title Affirms All Creatures Have a Common Creator" that the title "*Laudato si'*" selected by Pope Francis for his encyclical on the environment, originates from a hymn of praise by St. Francis of Assisi, highlighting the importance of living in unity with God, fellow creatures, and fellow humans (Cindy Wooden 2015). '*Laudato si'*' can be translated as either "Be Praised" or "Praised Be." This phrase is a recurring theme in St. Francis' poem or prayer, where he celebrates God's marvelous works through every creature in the world (Xue Jiao Zhang 2016, 45).

In the introductory section of the encyclical letter, there is a brief titled "St. Francis of Assisi," where Pope Francis explicitly acknowledges his desire to write this encyclical in homage to the profound influence of St. Francis (Francis 2015, no. 10). He wants readers to understand the extent to which his life and ideas are

shaped by the legacy of this remarkable figure (Xue Jiao Zhang 2016, 46).

It has been argued that this strong stance of Pope Francis is a radical departure from the traditional anthropocentric theology championed by Saint Thomas Aquinas. For nearly five centuries, the Thomistic reasoning that the natural world should be protected primarily for human benefit was predominant in the Church. In contrast, the message of *Laudato si'* advocates for the protection of nonhuman creation for its intrinsic value (Michael S. Northcott 2016, 888). The belief that anthropocentrism is a major hindrance to environmental responsibility is strongly supported by a wide range of theological perspectives (John O'Keefe 2013, 85). In this paper, therefore, we shall examine how Pope Francis' theology, influenced by the Franciscan ethos, can contribute to the welfare and flourishing both of humans and non-human creation. First, I will describe the environmental issues highlighted by Pope Francis that also have a bearing on humanity. I will then critically examine the philosophical views of Saint Thomas Aquinas, whose perspectives are central to the anthropocentric stance. This will be followed by an exposition of the thoughts of Francis of Assisi and two prominent Franciscan scholars, Saint Bonaventure and John Duns Scotus, and their influence on Pope Francis' thoughts. The concluding part will discuss how Franciscan theology can contribute to the advancement of human welfare.

1. The Evolution of Catholic Eco-Theology: From Paul VI to Pope Francis

Celia Deane-Drummond has demonstrated that the historical course of the Catholic Church's involvement with environmental issues sets the backdrop for Pope Francis' integral ecology. She adeptly traces this trajectory back to 1971, highlighting the Church's early reflections on eco-theology and its acknowledgment of environmental problems as consequences of human actions (Celia Deane-Drummond 2021, 194).

1.1. Pope Paul VI: Early Recognition of Environmental Degradation

The Church's first authoritative response to environmental issues surfaces in Paul VI's Apostolic letter, dated May 14, 1971, titled "*Octogesima Adveniens*." Here, environmental problems are portrayed as unforeseen and perceptible consequences of human actions, representing an imprudent misuse of nature leading to both environmental degradation and self-victimization. The pontiff prophetically asserts that, the physical environment is becoming increasingly hazardous due to garbage, pollution, emerging diseases, and unchecked destructive potential. This, in turn, may lead to an unsustainable future, posing a broad social issue affecting every individual (Paul VI 1971, no. 21).

In 1971, the World Synod of Catholic Bishops directly implicated more affluent nations for environmental deterioration, emphasizing the adverse impacts of their waste disposal into the atmosphere and oceans. It warned that such actions could lead to irreversible harm to crucial elements supporting life on Earth, such as air and water, and underscored the magnitude of the damage if the escalating levels of pollution exhibited by these nations were extended to the entire global population. Citing Romans 8:22, the document reinforces the notion of the suffering of creation, likening it to the process of giving birth (World Synod of Catholic Bishops in Australia, no. 19).

1.2. Pope John Paul II: Linking Ecology to Moral and Social Issues

Pope John Paul II continued this tradition, linking the suffering of creation to technological exploitation in his inaugural encyclical "*Redemptoris Hominis*" similarly referencing Romans 8 (John Paul II 2020, no. 8). He articulates ecological concerns, highlighting the threats posed by unbridled technological advancements and the alienation of humans from nature (Peter C. Phan, 1994, 67n4). The encyclical emphasizes the interconnectedness of social

devastations, including environmental destruction, nuclear war, disrespect for unborn life, and unchecked technology (John Paul II 2020, no. 16). This perspective contrasts with the prevailing notion of nature as a mere resource for immediate use, with critiques extended to financial and political systems, attributing them to global problems and environmental degradation (Ibid., no. 15).

The publication of *Sollicitudo Rei Socialis* in 1987 introduced the concept of ‘super-development,’ indicating excessive use of goods within ‘structures of sin’ (Celia Deane-Drummond 2021, 198f). Pope Francis harshly critiques a form of “super-development” characterized by an excessive abundance of material goods, enslaving people to the pursuit of possession and immediate gratification. Beyond ecological concerns, the encyclical critiques financial and political systems, attributing them to global problems and environmental degradation, highlighting their role in spreading misery and depleting resources (John Paul II 1993, no. 28). Drawing upon *Sollicitudo Rei Socialis* 34 and his message for the World Day of Peace 1987, the Pontiff associates the environmental issue closely with the problem of consumerism or “the culture of consumption” (John Paul II 1991, no. 37).

Significantly the saint Pope shows why the ecological crisis is fundamentally a moral issue. Deviation from the Creator’s intended plan by individuals instigates a disturbance affecting the entire created order, reflecting a lack of harmony between man and God that manifests in the state of the Earth itself (John Paul II 1990, no. 5). The ecological crisis as a moral issue manifests in three ways (Peter C. Phan 1994, 60). Firstly, it stems from the indiscriminate utilization of advancements in science and technology, particularly within industry and agriculture. Secondly, various forms of environmental degradation reveal a disregard for life, compromising human dignity. In *Centesimus Annus*, the Pope attributes this ethical lapse to what he terms as an “anthropological error” (John Paul II 1991, no. 37). Thirdly, unethical biological research and genetic manipulation contribute to the ecological

crisis, extending beyond plant and animal life to encompass human life (John Paul II 1990, no. 7). These moral shortcomings contravene fundamental principles, disrupting the delicate ecological equilibrium and working to the detriment of humankind (John Paul II 1993, 36f).

1.3. Pope Benedict XVI: Ethical Dimensions and Reductionist Views

Pope Benedict XVI further emphasized the ethical dimensions of ecological issues. He posits that the ecological issue presents profound ethical dimensions, exemplified by a conspicuous lack of reverence for life evident in instances of environmental pollution. The relentless pursuit of production interests often relegates the dignity of workers, leading to pollution and environmental degradation. In these scenarios, the root cause lies in an unnatural and reductionist perspective that promotes, at times, a genuine disregard for humanity (Benedict XVI 2009, no. 48). This reductionist viewpoint not only poses harm to the environment but also encourages activities that disregard human nature itself. He laments that development suffers significant harm due to distorted notions centered around the pursuit of complete technical mastery over nature, viewing nature as a mere raw material to be manipulated at our discretion, resulting in reckless exploitation that further exacerbates the ecological crisis (Ibid., no. 49).

1.4. Pope Francis: Integral Ecology and Systemic Critique

The historical developments outlined above provide the context for Pope Francis's vision, which builds on his predecessors' foundations and delivers a compelling message that transcends traditional boundaries.

1.4.1. Portrayal of Earth as Sister and Mother

Central to Pope Francis' message is the portrayal of our "Sister, Mother Earth" as a living entity capable of suffering and groaning under the weight of exploitation and neglect (Francis 2015, no. 1 &

53). This portrayal is a radical departure from metaphorical understandings, positioning the Earth as a central figure in Christian theology, akin to the most abandoned and maltreated among the poor (Bruno Latour & Stephen Muecke 2016, 253). The theological innovation is further amplified by referencing Romans 8:22, which equates the Earth's groaning with the groaning of all creation in travail (Francis 2015, no. 2). This association underlines a shared genealogy of violence and exploitation, intertwining the fates of the Earth, nature, and the impoverished in a shared narrative of suffering and hope for redemption (Bruno Latour & Stephen Muecke 2016, 254).

1.4.2. Systemic Critique of Structures and Actors

Expanding his critique beyond individual actions, Pope Francis confronts systemic structures and actors that perpetuate environmental degradation and social injustice, including financiers, CO₂ emitters, industrialists, and polluters (Francis 2015, nos. 4,13,41,48,56,61,122,145f & 163). This bold stance underscores the encyclical's broader critique of contemporary environmental and economic practices (Bruno Latour & Stephen Muecke 2016, 255).

1.4.3. Exploration of Environmental and Social Challenges

The encyclical explores a broad array of environmental challenges, including global warming, biodiversity loss, the presence of hazardous chemicals and waste, marine pollution, deforestation, monoculture plantations, and the lack of access to clean drinking water. It also addresses social issues such as inequality, greed, and poverty, highlighting the interconnectedness of environmental and social justice (Gerardo M. Ceballos 2016, 286). The first chapter which mostly discusses these issues is notably the most widely read and perhaps the only one that many people have engaged with, underscoring its accessibility and impact (A. M. C. Waterman 2017, 376). Pope Francis' prioritization of issues is particularly

striking, beginning with the loss of biodiversity before moving on to climate change and the broader degradation of earth systems. This ordering situates the climate change discussion within the larger framework of the planet's overall health and functionality. He employs theological language to describe human activities that cause harmful changes to the Earth, depicting them as sinful actions. Although Chapter 1 reverses this sequence, Pope Francis ingeniously places climate change within the wider scope of ecological issues, evincing strategic contextualization (Celia Deane-Drummond 2016, 394).

1.4.4. The Technocratic Paradigm: A Critique of Instrumental Exploitation and Its Cultural, Economic, and Ecological Impacts

Central to Pop Francis' critique is the notion of the technocratic paradigm. The term "technocratic paradigm" refers to a worldview that treats nature merely as an object to be used, managed, and exploited, promoting an instrumental perspective that values nature only for its utility or as a resource for consumption (Anna Rowlands 2021, 276). This paradigm, deeply entrenched in politics and economics, is characterized by a tendency towards uniform, simplistic solutions and actions driven by a desire for control and mastery as a means to achieve transformation (Ibid., 210). This perspective regards creation and nature as passive entities to be acted upon, rather than as living, communicating forms with intrinsic value beyond their utilitarian use. Within this paradigm, culture is seen as the active force shaping nature to meet human ends, promoting a dichotomy that leads to practices focused on human domination and control over the natural world (Ibid., 276).

Francis' pessimistic view, particularly in paragraphs 106–10 and the highlighting of the ruthless and destructive nature of technology as a driving force for progress in modernity in paragraphs 16 and 17, are thought to be influenced by the German philosopher of religion Romano Guardini, whose works Francis studied in the 1980s. Guardini's work, especially "The End of the

Modern World,” serves as a significant intellectual context for *Laudato si'* (Wolfgang Sachs 2018; A. M. C. Waterman 2016, 385). Francis also connects his critique to a broader papal tradition opposing the instrumentalization of nature and the technocratic mindset, citing John Paul II's “*Redemptor Hominis*” and “*Caritas in Veritate*” (Anna Rowlands 2021, 276-7n12). He incorporates Guardini's ideas, particularly highlighting the ruthless and destructive nature of technology as a driving force for progress in modernity (Francis 2016, nos. 16f). Despite these glimpses of change, Pope Francis notes a gradual loss of faith in the incessant pursuit of technological novelties to fuel progress, resulting in feelings of emptiness and a lack of depth in life (Ibid., no. 114, referred to in Celia Deane-Drummond 2023, 104).

He argues that the technocratic paradigm has evolved into a self-sustaining epistemology, shaping a normative way of being and maintaining the status quo in culture, economy, and politics. He describes this paradigm as elevating a conception of the human subject who seeks to dominate and control nature through logical and rational means, a shift from a harmonious interaction with nature to an aggressive exploitation of it. This shift has facilitated the acceptance of unlimited growth based on the erroneous belief in an inexhaustible abundance of natural resources, leading to the overexploitation of the planet (Anna Rowlands 2021, 278).

According to Pope Francis, the technocratic paradigm, where progress is driven by the relentless exploitation of the environment, leads to suffering for both the environment and the poor (Francis 2015, no. 109). Criticism of progress and skepticism toward a simplistic belief in progress are not new phenomena. However, the ecological crisis, a consequence of industrial society and intricately linked with technical progress, is a distinctive characteristic of the modern era. Pope Francis, drawing from his experiences in Latin America, particularly witnessing ecological and economic overexploitation, underscores this specific aspect of the modern age. The environmental and economic challenges

associated with industrialization are vividly reflected in this context (Reinhard Cardinal Marx 2016, 299).

The technocratic mindset, the encyclical argues, exacerbates the exploitation of both the Earth and the human poor in addressing environmental issues (Francis 2015, no. 117). According to Pope Francis, such pragmatism perpetuates a modern misunderstanding of the nature of humans and masks the injustices at the root of the crisis. *Laudato si'* corresponds with various critical discourses in the environmental humanities by suggesting that when problem-solving rationality shapes our understanding of human personhood and its connection with Earth, we inadequately comprehend ecological problems. However, political privilege collaborates with technocratic pragmatism to shield us from Earth's disruptions in that manner. The alliance between wealth and power embraces the type of pragmatism that, by pursuing technical solutions, stifles critical examination of inequalities. The heightened management of environments through markets and engineering, ingrains the advantages of the wealthy into the landscape (Willis Jenkins 2018, 445).

1.4.5. Critique of Climate Change as a Global Issue

Integral to Pope Francis' teaching is his critique of Climate change described as a "global problem with grave implications: environmental, social, economic, political, and for the distribution of goods" (Francis 2015, no. 25). Traditionally, Catholic social thought seldom tackled climate change directly. However, Pope Francis, continuing the efforts of his predecessors, has incorporated a discussion on the social impacts of climate change, reflecting a broader global perspective (Celia Deane-Drummond 2015, 394). By spotlighting the direct effects on human lives, such as compromised access to clean water, energy, and agriculture, and the looming threat of rising sea levels, the encyclical aims to connect climate issues with individuals' daily experiences (Francis 2015, no. 24). It addresses the disconnection some feel towards their role as moral agents in combating climate change, using

tangible examples like the acute scarcity of clean water (Ibid., no. 30) to underline the message (Celia Deane-Drummond 2015, 396).

Pope Francis asserts that “the climate is a common good, belonging to all and meant for all” (Francis 2015, no. 23), acknowledging the complexity of the global climate system and the consensus on its alarming warming (Gerardo M. Ceballos 2016, 287). Predictions suggest that by 2047, the Earth may experience a “global climate departure,” where even the coldest years will be warmer than any recorded between 1866 and 2005. This indicates a profound shift in what is considered “normal” (Ibid., 288). Climate disruption manifests in various ways—temperature shifts, altered rainfall patterns, ice cap melting, and rising sea levels, to name a few, posing significant threats to humanity’s survival. It’s no surprise that a significant portion of *Laudato si’* is dedicated to discussing these implications (Ibid., 287).

These notions are furthered in *Laudate Deum*, a subsequent apostolic exhortation, which coincided with the 2023 UN Climate Change Conference (COP28), which stresses the escalating severity of the climate crisis, framing it as a fundamental issue concerning human life and dignity on a global scale and the urgent need for immediate measures to mitigate its impacts on both the environment and disadvantaged communities. According to the Pontiff, climate change increasingly jeopardizes the well-being of individuals and families across various aspects of life including healthcare, employment opportunities, resource accessibility, housing, and forced migration (Francis 2023, nos. 2f).

1.4.6. The Cry of the Earth and the Cry of the Poor

“The cry of the earth and the cry of the poor” serves as a unifying theme in Francis’ integral ecology, highlighting the interconnected suffering of both. Through this expression, Pope Francis, inspired by St. Francis of Assisi, establishes a profound connection between ecological concerns and the socio-economic issues responsible for exploitation and poverty (Alexandre A. Martins 2018, 419, 422).

Wolfgang Sachs explains why Pope Francis establishes this connection. As an increasing number of people inhabit a finite planet, social inequality intertwines with ecological issues. Typically, the affluent consume resources that would otherwise be available to the less privileged. In essence, the global middle and upper classes are leading a luxurious lifestyle, leading the encyclical to connect poverty and environmental degradation, noting that both scientific research and daily experiences reveal that the most severe consequences of environmental harm are borne by the poorest ((Wolfgang Sachs 2018).

Alexandra A. Martins notes two significant influences on Pope Francis in this regard. First, there is the influence of Leonardo Boff, a Brazilian theologian. Boff's work on ecological issues and social injustice, rooted in liberation theology since the 1980s, resonates with Francis' call for a holistic perspective. Boff advocates for a shift from the exploitative "spirit of geometry" to a more humane "spirit of finesse," emphasizing tenderness, caring, humility, and community. Both Boff and Francis call for a new paradigm centered on ecological and social justice, rejecting the dominance of market forces in safeguarding the environment (Alexandre A. Martins 2018, 421).

Second, the concept of institutionalized violence has been underscored in CELAM's documents since 1968, emphasizing the interconnectedness of ecological and social issues. Consistent with this analytical tradition, Francis rejects the notion of two distinct crises, asserting that the current predicament is a complex interplay of both social and environmental crises (Ibid., 419).

The intimate connection between the earth and the poor is emphasized by Francis, by beginning his encyclical by classifying the earth as among "the most abandoned and maltreated of our poor" (Francis 2015, no. 2). According to his perspective, the earth is also a vulnerable entity requiring care, alongside the humans who suffer the initial consequences of an exploitative approach to the earth Ibid.; Alexandre A. Martins 2018, 419). Francis recognizes

that human inequality mutes the cry of the Earth because it promotes a mindset among the privileged that moralizes their exercise of power as brilliant mastery and responsible management. *Laudato si'* suggests that Sister Earth has been silenced by injustice and sinful rationalizations of that injustice. Power dulls the senses of individuals in technocratic cultures, while inequality discourages the wealthy from hearing the cries of both the poor and the Earth (Willis Jenkins 2018, 446). As Francis puts it, “this sister now cries out to us because of ... our abuse of the goods with which God has endowed her,” and the mindset legitimizing this abuse also silences her voice: Humans now view themselves as rulers over the Earth, believing they can freely exploit it. The aggression in their hearts, tainted by sin, is mirrored in the environmental degradation seen in soil, water, air, and all living creatures (Francis 2015, no. 2).

The term “ecological debt” in the encyclical highlights the significant environmental debts accumulated by the wealthy in the global north, often overlooked due to geographical, temporal, and social distances. The poor disproportionately bear the consequences of the global north’s affluence (Wolfgang Sachs 2018). Francis considers this phenomenon a structural exploitation of the earth, resulting from the unrestrained use of nature and a single-minded pursuit of profit, as a key contributor to the creation of poverty (Francis 2015, nos. 2, 93 & 190). In *Spes Non Confundit* he explicates how this exploitation works. He asserts that the ecological imbalance between the Global North and South stems from commercial disparities, impacting the environment due to certain countries’ prolonged and disproportionate utilization of natural resources (Francis 2024). The narrative emerges that chemical toxins coincidentally concentrate in brown and black neighborhoods, as if that were their natural habitat. In the realm of climate, it starts to appear natural that rising waters engulf coastal settlements along southern seas but miraculously halt against the defenses of North Atlantic cities. As exclusions and vulnerabilities are normalized by managerial responses, wealthy white populations

paradoxically enhance their advantages over others by addressing problems that they disproportionately caused in the first place (Willis Jenkins 2018, 446). Therefore, Pope Francis rightly observes that the current lifestyle and business practices of the global north are unsustainable and cannot be universally applied without harming the planet. He criticizes the notion that some consider themselves more human than others, born with greater rights (Francis 2015, no. 90).

The interconnectedness between the suffering of the earth and the poor is further underscored by his discussion on biodiversity loss. The planet is undergoing a significant onslaught on its biodiversity, resulting in the loss of millions of populations and thousands of species (Gerardo M. Ceballos 2016, 290). The expansion of industrial and agricultural activities has encroached upon forests and woodlands, resulting in a significant loss of species diversity. This encroachment is particularly pronounced in tropical rainforests, often referred to as the “lungs of our planet” (Francis 2015, no. 38), where it diminishes their crucial capacity to absorb carbon dioxide (Ibid., nos. 32-42). Pope Francis extensively addresses this critical issue, emphasizing every year, thousands of plant and animal species vanish, lost to us forever, unseen by us and our children (Ibid., no. 32).

The responsibility for biodiversity loss is unequivocally attributed to human activity, with the author underscoring its profound consequences. As Pope Francis states, due to human actions, numerous species will no longer glorify God through their existence or convey their message to humans (Ibid., no 33). Pope Francis rightly emphasizes that the depletion of forests and woodlands means losing species that could be crucial resources in the future, not just for food but also for medicine and other purposes (Ibid., no 32).

There are some noteworthy differences in Pope Francis’ ecological theology despite its continuity with that of his predecessors. Although papal encyclicals have traditionally

addressed environmental and social issues, the ecological dimension was typically framed within the context of Catholic concerns for social justice (Celia Deane-Drummond 2021, 394). However, *Laudato si'* deliberately reverses this order, prioritizing the discussion of the ecological crisis while still acknowledging the essential social aspects of the issue (Steven C. van den Heuvel 2018, 52, 64). Thus, the encyclical is remarkable for what Lorenzo Orioli describes as its “absolute novelty.” He explains that, for the first time ever, an official document of the Catholic Church is exclusively dedicated to social and environmental issues (Lorenzo Orioli 2016, 933).

Anthropocentrism is highlighted as leading to an ecological crisis. Therefore, in what follows, we shall examine first the creation philosophy of St. Thomas Aquinas, considered a champion of anthropocentrism, and Pope Francis’ critique of it. This analysis will be followed by an investigation of the environmental theology of the Franciscan tradition and Pope Francis’ integration of it into his concept of integral ecology.

2. Aquinas’ Hierarchical View of Creation and Ethical Implications

2.1. Influence of Albertus Magnus on Aquinas’ Thought

Thomas Aquinas was influenced greatly by his mentor, Albertus Magnus (Celia Deane-Drummond and Agustín Fuentes 2014, 216). Albertus Magnus explores the notion that the soul is intricately linked with semen, bestowing animals with the capacity for reproduction. The concept of the nourishing soul present within the conceived semen of an animal arises from the understanding that semen, originating from animals, inherently carries the potential for life. This soul exists in a latent form within the combined sperm, indicating an inherent capability that signifies an action of the soul from the parent generating it. However, the emergence of the rational soul in humans deviates from this biological process. Its formation is ascribed to a more profound cause: the illumination

emanating from the primary intellect, which he views as embodying a divine, eternal, and indestructible essence. Magnus posits that this distinction is pivotal in differentiating humans from other animals, ascribing to humans a unique possession of a rational soul (Albertus Magnus, book 16, chapter 12, no. 65). Albertus Magnus explores the notion of animal virtues, suggesting that the origin of all perfections and imperfections in animals is fundamentally linked to the extent to which they fully or partially embody the inherent virtues unique to their species. However, he qualifies this by measuring perfection relative to humans, emphasizing the need to determine the true nature of the most perfect animal (Ibid., book 21, chapter 1, no. 1). According to Albertus Magnus, the perfection of the vegetative and sensible soul comes through participating in reason to some extent. He categorizes virtues based on the soul's gradations, attributing temperance and chastity to the functions of the vegetative soul, while virtues such as humility, gentleness, and fortitude are linked to the desires and angers of the sensitive soul. This hierarchy corresponds with the concept of a nested structure, where the relationship between the vegetative and sensible soul can be likened to a triangle to a quadrangle (Celia Deane-Drummond and Agustín Fuentes 2014, 265).

2.2. Hierarchical Structure of Creation

The teachings of his mentor significantly influenced the Angelic Doctor in his exposition of rationality and animal virtues. Aquinas argues that in the natural world, species appear to be organized hierarchically, with mixed substances being superior to basic elements, plants surpassing minerals, animals exceeding plants, and humans surpassing other animals (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica* I q. 47, a. 2). Entities below the level of human beings are regarded as “less perfect” and exist to fulfill the requirements of those considered “more perfect” (Ibid., q. 65, a. 2). Aquinas is criticized for being anthropocentric due to this perspective on

creation, which allows humans to exploit less perfect beings for their own benefit (Anatoly Angelo R. Aseneta 2017, 231).

According to Aquinas, the structure of creation comprises various formal differences (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica* I q.5, a.3). However, since formal differentiation inherently involves inequality, the diversity within creation also implies a hierarchy where some entities are superior to others (Ibid., q.47, a.2). Aquinas categorizes the forms of life into three hierarchically arranged classifications of souls: vegetative, sensitive, and rational (Ibid., q.78, a.1). At the bottom of the soul hierarchy is the vegetative soul, which lacks consciousness and rationality but possesses the abilities of nutrition, growth, and reproduction (Ibid., q.79, a. 2). The next tier is occupied by the sensitive soul. Here, Aquinas assigns all nonhuman animals, as they possess not only vegetative characteristics but also external and internal senses, albeit lacking rationality (Ibid., q.78, a.1; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa contra Gentiles* II.66). Aquinas argues that higher forms of perfection encompass the lower ones (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica* I q. 76, a. 5). Therefore, the human soul embodies traits of both the vegetative and sensitive souls, but its superiority lies in its rationality (Ibid., q. 91, a. 1).

2.3. Aquinas on the Divine Image and Rationality in Human Beings

Human life, encompassing spiritual, bodily, or imaginative ways of knowing, is said to be capable of bearing a “trace” of the image (Aquinas, *Summa Theologica* XIII, 1a, q. 93, a. 6). Aquinas maintains that the distinctive quality distinguishing humans as bearers of God’s image is their greater capacity for the highest good, coupled with the intelligence directed toward revealed knowledge. The resemblance to God is so profound that within all creation, nothing else comes closer. Hence, it’s clear that only intelligent beings genuinely reflect God’s image. In this context, intelligence refers to the quality that distinguishes human reasoning from that of other animals. This distinction, according to Aquinas,

lies in the greater cognitive capacity for abstract thought and contemplation of the highest good in humans compared to other animals (Ibid., q. 93, a. 2). Aquinas emphasizes that the operations of the rational side in human beings are different, even considering them as incorporeal. He contends that sensation in humans cannot be true or false, nor can it be deceived in the manner cognition can be. Therefore, Aquinas rejects the idea that rationality is a type of sensation (Thomas Aquinas, *Aristotlis De Anima Commentarium*, book III, chapter 4, pars. 199–215). It is essential to note that Aquinas doesn't conceive intellect as separated from the rest of human nature in a dualistic ontology. Instead, cognition in humans is a unique process, both in terms of receiving what is intelligible through intellect and through agency related to the power of abstraction (Ibid., chapter 10, pars. 101–106).

Celia Dean-Drummond clarifies that since wisdom, as he defined it, pertains to knowledge of eternal things, it appears that it is the intelligence of humans directed toward the capacity for revealed knowledge that distinguishes human image-bearing, rather than merely intellectual capacity. Importantly, such capacities to receive revelation are not merely “added” to an otherwise brutish human nature in a dualistic manner; instead, human nature remains creaturely and mortal but possesses the potential for transformation (Celia Deane-Drummond 2012, 936).

Aquinas further explores this idea, asserting that the ability to reflect God's image endures even when reasoning abilities are impaired. He describes the image of God as varying significantly across individuals: it is nearly absent in those who are incapable of reasoning, appears faint and distorted in sinners, and, conversely, is clear and splendid in the virtuous. This variation underscores the concept that the presence and clarity of God's likeness within us fluctuate based on our moral conduct and cognitive capabilities (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XIII, 1a, q. 93, a. 8).

In Aquinas' view, humans have a more elaborate memory compared to other animals, involving an inner reminiscence and a

quasi-syllogistic search among memories of past events. He acknowledged that other animals also exhibit common sense and imagination. However, he argued that cognition and memory in humans reach higher levels due to their similarity and connection with abstract reason, making them more perfect versions of the same powers found in other animals. Despite the emphasis on reason as a high watermark for humans, Aquinas acknowledges important qualifications. He recognizes that animals, too, can act not only in response to external sensations but also based on an inner judgment about what might be useful or harmful (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XI, 1a, q.78, a. 4), which differs from human deliberation characterized by a universal shrewdness, acting as the measure for all possible activities (Celia Deane-Drummond 2009, 939). While some animals display a partial reflection of practical wisdom or prudence a form of moral agency (Celia Deane-Drummond 2014, 90), it is only fully evident in humans, where sound judgment about how things should be done is present (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XVI, 1a2ae q. 3, a. 1). According to Thomas, Optimal prudence is present in humans, who possess the ability to reason regarding their behaviors, while a form of incomplete prudence can be observed in certain wild animals, which have specific instincts for particular behaviors that resemble prudent actions (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I-II q. 3, a. 6). He speaks of nonhuman animals as operating primarily out of instinct (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XXI, 1a2ae q. 46, a. 4) stimulated by external factors, even though Aquinas allows for some “purposive perception” in other animals (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XVI, 1a2ae, q. 1, a. 2).

Aquinas acknowledges that human beings may at times be driven by external forces, but when they carry out orders blindly, they are considered to be acting more like nonrational creatures (Ibid., q. 1, a. 3). He emphasizes the importance of deliberate and self-conscious willing in defining human acts (Celia Dean-Drummond 2014, 68). This perspective elevates human reason over

emotional bodily actions, a view that has been subject to criticism (Janet Martin Soskice 2007, 27f).

2.4. Aquinas' View on Instinct, Animal Capacities, and Ethical Controversies

The crucial aspect in understanding Aquinas' perspective lies in his discussion of the meaning of instinct. Specifically, he associated instinct with the estimative sense and practical wisdom, or prudence (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XXI, 1a2ae, q. 46, a. 4). Aquinas posited the estimative faculty is a capacity that, though not rational in a human sense, is influenced by a higher form of reason—divine reason from God. This allows their behaviors to reflect aspects of moral virtue, exhibiting a resemblance to moral goodness. Thus, nonhuman animals, as beings under divine law, partake in divine reason, which grants their emotions and capacities a semblance to those found in humans, according to Aquinas' perspective on the natural order (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XIX, 1a2ae, q. 24, a. 4).¹ Hence, he acknowledges that other entities merely mirror God in a trace-like manner (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XIII, 1a, q. 93, a. 6). However, he later dismisses this notion (Celia Dean-Drummond 2014, 936).

The estimative sense in other animals, according to Aquinas, is related to the appetitive power of the soul. Animals seek after what they know, but the intellectual appetite of human beings differs from the sensitive appetite of other animals (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XI, 1a, q. 80, a. 1).

In accordance with their intrinsic ability to assess things, animals possess a certain level of cleverness in specific activities. However, humans possess, or have the potential to possess, a comprehensive cleverness that serves as a standard for all conceivable activities. This capacity for cleverness and reasoning is demonstrated in various animal behaviors, such as cranes and wild geese following a leader, and bees obeying their queen (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XIII, 1a. q. 96, a. 1).

Aquinas recognizes certain shared characteristics with other animals, such as the capacity for friendship or hostility in the active irascible appetite; however, he maintains a hierarchical view of these appetites. The highest level of activity in the irascible appetite touches the lowest rungs of reasonable activity (Thomas Aquinas, *Quaestiones Disputatae de Veritate* III, q. 25, a. 2).

Despite admitting to certain capacities in other animals, Aquinas maintains that the purpose of animals is to serve humanity. One controversial aspect of Aquinas' views is his assertion that other animals, even though innocent, can be punished "by divine law" for the sole purpose of punishing the human beings who own them. This punishment, according to Aquinas, serves to correct, frighten, or instruct humans (Ibid., q. 24, a. 2). This position has been criticized for contributing to the negative treatment of animals, and Aquinas has been vilified in some circles for his ethical stance on the use of animals by humans (Celia Dean-Drummond 2014, 68).

3. Beyond Human Utility: Embracing Creation's Intrinsic Worth in Franciscan Theology

One of the defining features of *Laudato si'* is Pope Francis' critique of anthropocentrism or his departure from the Thomistic anthropocentric perspective on non-human nature. While Francis consistently uses the term anthropocentrism in a negative light, he always qualifies it. He describes it as distorted anthropocentrism, misguided anthropocentrism, tyrannical anthropocentrism, modern anthropocentrism, and excessive anthropocentrism (Francis 2015, nos. 68f, 115f, 118f & 122). However, he never outright rejects anthropocentrism, suggesting an acknowledgment that it is not inherently negative. Instead of misguided anthropocentrism, there could be a correct anthropocentrism; instead of distorted anthropocentrism, a true anthropocentrism; and instead of modern or excessive anthropocentrism, an appropriate anthropocentrism rooted in authentic Christian tradition. Anthropocentrism can be interpreted in various ways, and the issue lies in the type of

anthropocentrism being endorsed. What would a ‘correct’ or ‘authentic’ anthropocentrism entail (Carmody T. S. Grey 2016)? To gain a better understanding of the anthropocentrism endorsed by Pope Francis, let’s explore his primary influence: Franciscan environmental theology.

3.1. St. Francis of Assisi’s Transformative Vision

According to Bonaventure, the founder of the Franciscan order, originating from a privileged background, underwent a profound inner transformation to connect himself with the poor and nature. Bonaventure recounts a pivotal moment in the Life of St. Francis, where he encounters a leper while riding through the plain near Assisi. He dismounts and approaches the leper, offering both money and a kiss, overcoming the barrier of privilege that had separated him from those in need (Bonaventure, *The Life of Saint Francis*, chapter 1).

This encounter marks the beginning of Francis’ journey towards reconciliation with others, nature, and God. By embracing his authentic humanity, he engages in transformative interactions with both people and the environment (Jean-Pierre Fortin 2018, 71). His encounter with the leper profoundly impacted him, sparking a lifelong commitment to reconciliation not only with society’s outcasts but with all living beings. St. Francis’ interactions with the natural world further fueled his reverence for nature, turning him into a fervent advocate for environmental stewardship. This deep love and repentant spirit toward nature and the vulnerable not only shaped St. Francis’ identity and spiritual expression but also instilled in him a heightened sensitivity to ecological concerns.

In the poetic masterpiece *Canticle of the Sun* through his choice of language—terms like sister, brother, mother, and Sister Mother Earth—St. Francis encapsulates his ecological sensitivity, particularly evident in his profound relationship with God through every earthly creature (Xue Jiao Zhang 2016, 46-8). One of the key

aspects of Francis' Canticum is its plea to move beyond a utilitarian perspective on elements of creation beyond humanity and towards a more familial or fraternal outlook on the inherent worth of all aspects of creation (Daniel P. Horan 2018, 145). For Francis, nothing existed simply for human exploitation or consumption; rather, everything was part of God's majestic creation, interconnected with all other aspects in a divine web (Leonardo Boff 1997, 203f).

The late Franciscan theologian Eric Doyle describes the Canticum as a sublime declaration of the genuine Christian approach to creation, which involves embracing and cherishing creatures just as they are, as an act of praise to God the Creator (Eric Doyle 2002, 157f). Francis doesn't perceive humanity as separate from the rest of creation; instead, he emphasizes that all individuals must remember to offer praise to God by being in right relationships, showing forgiveness, bearing burdens, and enduring in peace (Francis of Assisi, *The Canticum of the Creatures*, v. 10).

3.2. Bonaventure's Theology of Pietas and Kinship

Bonaventure underscores Francis' emphasis on kinship by revisiting the Roman understanding of *pietas*. In Roman culture, *pietas* primarily pertained to filial responsibilities towards parents, extending to other family members, deceased relatives, and deities (Stefan Heid 2011, 406-26). The Latin roots of "piety" suggest a broader significance, one that resonates more intimately with daily life. In ancient Rome, *pietas* denoted filial duty, primarily concerning the care of one's parents and, secondarily, extended to the care of other family members, the deceased, and even deities. However, Bonaventure expands its application beyond humans, encompassing nonhuman entities in his writings. In Chapter Eight of his Major Legend of Saint Francis, Bonaventure explicitly links "pietas" to nonhuman beings, whom he refers to as "irrational creatures," when discussing Francis' relationship with the entire created world (Bonaventure, *Legenda Maior*, chapter 8). Bonaventure attributes Francis' holistic view of creation and his

acknowledgment of the inherent kinship among all beings to his sense of “*pietas*” (Daniel P. Horan 2021, 13)

Bonaventure emphasizes how nonhuman creatures themselves acknowledge this kinship with Francis and humanity, expressing it in ways natural to their species. He urges readers to contemplate the remarkable power and sweetness of piety in Francis, which even animals recognized in their own way (Bonaventure, *Legenda Maior*, chapter 6).

In addition to recognizing the reciprocal nature of *pietas* as a virtue shared by both Francis and nonhuman creatures he encountered, Bonaventure also highlights the agency of these creatures in shaping narratives of Francis’ interactions with them. An illustrative example is found in the account of Francis’ encounter with a sheep. This passage is noteworthy in Bonaventure’s theological discourse on creation and nonhuman agency (Daniel P. Horan 2021, 14). Bonaventure meticulously describes how this supposedly “irrational” animal displayed traits that correspond with human standards of rationality. Additionally, the sheep exhibited moral agency by adhering to Francis’ admonition to “avoid giving offense to the brothers,” highlighting its fraternal relationship with the Franciscan friars (Bonaventure, *Legenda Maior*, chapter 8).

All these instances of nonhuman agency, rationality, and moral decision-making contribute to Bonaventure’s reflections on the virtue of *pietas*, particularly in Francis’ exemplary embodiment of it. Bonaventure concludes by emphasizing the centrality of *pietas* in establishing and maintaining right relationships within creation, asserting that it binds all creatures together when embraced by both humans and nonhumans (Daniel P. Horan 2021, 14).

British Franciscan scholar Eric Doyle further contextualizes Francis’ perspective, explaining that for Francis, nature isn’t merely a reflection of human activity or reactions, as that would undermine the unique value of other creatures. Instead,

they are akin to humans in reflecting God. He wholeheartedly believes in the doctrine of creation, seeing the entire universe—including the self and its environment—as the result of divine creative power, an expression of transcendent love (Eric Doyle 1997, 158f).

St. Bonaventure University's Timothy Johnson suggests that Francis' acknowledgment of the independent, intrinsic value of all creation reflects his belief that creatures aren't objects but subjects in a vast network of relationships, characterized by equality and a shared source of vitality (Timothy Johnson 2012, 145). As subjects, non-human elements of creation possess a sense of agency that enables humanity to engage with them in a familial or fraternal manner (Ibid., 146).

Similarly, the medieval historian Jacques Dalarun refers to Francis' kinship-oriented approach to envisioning the community of creation as "the Franciscan revolution" (Jacques Dalarun 2016, 49f). This revolution radically asserts the fraternity and sorority of all creation, challenging medieval structures of domination and lordship with an alternative vision that carries theological, economic, and social implications, hinting at a political dimension. At the heart of this revolution is the world itself, with its diverse inhabitants, sentient and non-sentient alike. Central to Francis' vision is "Sister Mother Earth," whom he points to as an exemplar of right action. Dalarun describes this as a governance model characterized by maternal care, in stark contrast to paternal domination. By celebrating the one true Lord and recognizing praise, glory, and honor as belonging solely to God, Francis' approach undermines earthly lordships that oppressed the marginalized during the Middle Ages (Ibid., 52).

Bonaventure stands out as a prominent interpreter of St. Francis of Assisi's emerging theology of creation, contributing significantly to this tradition in various ways. He acknowledges the intrinsic relationality of all aspects of the world and integrates this understanding into his hierarchical view of creation.

He delineates three levels or orders within creation—vestige, image, and likeness. The foundational level is that of the vestige (*vestigium*), present in every aspect of creation. Bonaventure conceives each element of the created order as bearing a “footprint” of the divine, a unique imprint reflecting the source of its existence. As all creatures inherently relate to God as the principle of creation, they are vestiges (Bonaventure, *Quaestiones disputatae De scientia Christi*, q. 4). This inherent connection implies that every creature can reveal something about God to the rest of creation and is intrinsically linked to all other aspects, akin to what Francis identified as a cosmic *fraternitas* or contemporary kinship (J. A. Wayne Hellmann 2001, 147). This distinction in degrees reflects humanity’s exceptional ability to engage with the divine not only as the cause, but as its focus or is capable of acknowledging God (Bonaventure, *De scientia Christi*, q. 4).

Bonaventure’s hierarchical theology asserts that humans, besides being vestiges, also represent the image (*imago*) of God. The distinction lies in humanity’s cognitive capacity to relate to the divine not only as a cause (like all creation as vestiges) but also as an object. Moreover, Bonaventure explains that humanity, as part of creation, can reflect God through similitude or likeness. This occurs when humans, as images, unite themselves closely with God through grace, exhibiting an ordered soul and a proximity to the Creator that sin has otherwise limited. Bonaventure’s hierarchical depiction of the created world suggests that all created entities bear inherent resemblance to the Creator and extend this identity to other aspects of the community of creation. Additionally, his understanding of interrelatedness, characterized by a shared “family resemblance” acknowledging diversity and differentiation, underscores the unity of all creatures stemming from their common origin (Bonaventure, *Breviloquium* q. 2, a. 10).

According to Bonaventure, God is primarily understood as “fruitful being” or “supreme goodness,” from which creation emerges through a single act of divine will (Bonaventure,

Quaestiones disputatae de mysterio Ss. Trinitatis, q. 8). The mechanism through which this act of creation occurs, namely the expression of the divine will outside God's self, is through the uncreated, Eternal Word, identified as the Son (Bonaventure, *Collationes in Hexaëmeron*, 9.2 & 3.7). As Zachary Hayes explains, All facets of the Father's essence find expression in the Word, thereby concentrating the entirety of the triune Godhead, encompassing the procession of the Spirit, within the Word in an exemplary fashion (Zachary Hayes 1976, 314). This understanding corresponds with the eternal predestination, as God's knowledge and love for the creature extend from eternity, irrespective of human prejudice (Bonaventure, *Collationes in Hexaemeron*, 12:1-7).

Beyond the inherent interrelatedness rooted in his Trinitarian and Christological perspective, Bonaventure posits that the divine act of creation establishes harmony and order within creation. While human sinfulness often obscures this harmony, those who possess a mystical-prophetic outlook akin to Francis of Assisi can perceive it. In Bonaventure's *Itinerarium*, he links the divine attributes of goodness and beauty to the vestigial representation found in all creation (Bonaventure, *Itinerarium Mentis in Deum*, ch. I, vv. 14f). Franciscan theologian Sr. Ilia Delio of Villanova University further elucidates Bonaventure's synthesis, highlighting that the beauty, order, and harmony of creation signify its meaningfulness and purpose beyond merely serving as a backdrop to human endeavors (Ilia Delio 2001, 55).

Building upon the eternal sonship of the Incarnate Word, Bonaventure delves deeper into the concept of pietas by emphasizing exemplarity and our human obligation to emulate Christ's actions (Zachary Hayes 1992, 138f). According to him, we are all interconnected as members of the same body, nourished by the same sustenance and born from the same source. Hence, we should treat each other with reverence and kinship (Bonaventure, *Collationes de septem donis Spiritus Sancti*, conference 3). He

expands this notion beyond human interactions to encompass other-than-human creatures, referring to them as “irrational creatures” (Bonaventure, *Legenda Maior*, chapter 8), as they are created to praise God and contribute to humanity’s salvation (Timothy Johnson 2012, 150). Bonaventure attributes Francis’ understanding of the inherent kinship of creation to his piety, exemplified by Francis’ use of familial terms for all creatures, indicating a deep theological understanding rather than mere humility (Bonaventure, *Legenda Maior*, chapter 8). Despite this advocacy for loving irrational creatures, Bonaventure, a product of his time, maintained a somewhat qualified anthropocentric and hierarchical perspective on the order of creation (Christopher Cullen 2006, 130f). This stance represents a departure from Francis’ more egalitarian view that encompasses all of creation (Daniel P. Horan 2018, 152).

3.3. John Duns Scotus: Divine Freedom and Creation’s Harmony

Bonaventure is not the sole Franciscan theologian to expand upon Francis’ early theology of creation. According to Scotist scholar Mary Beth Ingham, it was in the writings of one of the greatest medieval metaphysicians, John Duns Scotus, that the Franciscan love for all creatures was both philosophically established and theologically defended (Mary Beth Ingham 2016, 471).

Scotus builds upon his Franciscan predecessor’s work, contending with Bonaventure that God freely chooses to engage in relationship, *ad extra*, through the act of creation (John Duns Scotus, *Quodlibet* q. 14, a. 16). In line with John’s Gospel, which states, “For God so loved the world that He gave His only Son, so that everyone who believes in Him may not perish but have eternal life” (Jn 3:16),² Scotus shows that creation is not a necessity and that God possesses absolute freedom to choose as desired. He emphasizes that the love that serves as the foundation of all creation is epitomized by the Incarnation (Ilia Delio 2003, 56f). This act of creation, according to Ingham, reflects God’s choice to share divine

goodness and create co-lovers of divine infinite goodness and beauty (Mary Beth Ingham 2003, 49).

Since there is a single source of all creation, there exists an intrinsic relationship shared among all entities within the created order, both in relation to the Creator and to each other. From this interrelationship arises a divinely intended harmony of creation, described by Scotus as the “order of essences.” This interconnectedness unifies the entirety of creation in harmonious accord (John Duns Scotus, *De Primo Principia*, 1.5).

Scotus’ conception of the harmony of creation surpasses Bonaventure’s initial and teleological understanding, encompassing a dynamic sense of relationship that includes both God and creatures. While Scotus maintains the inequality between God and creation, he posits a radical notion of “weak mutuality,” suggesting that despite their ontological inequality, the relationship with creation involves both God and creatures. Ingham elucidates that this essential order comprises a comprehensive sweep of being, a unified reality that includes God. As the First Principle, God exists within the order of being and in relationship with the created order (Mary Beth Ingham 2012, 38f). Scotus depicts this dynamic harmony within creation in terms of divine artistry or aesthetics. God, the Creator-Artist, lovingly brings the entire universe into existence and situates it within an ordered framework of interrelatedness (Mary Beth Ingham 2007, 49).

Scotus elucidates that alongside the rest of creation, each individual is chosen, created, and loved by God, possessing an inherent dignity and value known only to God (Daniel P. Horan 2007, 256). According to Scotus, material substance is defined uniquely by a specific positive entity, while other diverse singularities are determined by distinct positive entities (Bonaventure, *Lectura* II, d. 3, p. 1, q. 6). As Mary Beth Ingham and Mechthild Dreyer aptly summarize, Scotus proposes that material substance achieves individuality through a principle that contracts the common nature into singularity. Scotus refers to this

principle as the individuating entity or “thisness” or *haecceitas* (Mary Beth Ingham and Mechthild Dreyer 2004, 113). As Timothy Noone notes, Scotus values common natures (*natura communis*) too, but it is the individual that is of ultimate importance and should be valued prior to that which is shared in common (Timothy Noone 2003, 122). In essence, what distinguishes an individual entity as itself and not another is not an addition to the generic substance of categories like “dog,” “stone,” or “human (Daniel P. Horan 2018, 1063).

Since this individualizing aspect of each created being is a mystery known only to God—it cannot be measured or empirically observed. *Haecceitas* represents the ultimate reality of any entity. To summarize the divergence in thought between Scotus and Aquinas, Ingham asserts that according to Scotus, the created order is not merely a medium through which divine light shines (as Aquinas taught), but possesses an inherent light that emanates from within (Daniel P. Horan 2007, 253). Every entity within the fabric of creation inherently holds a dignity that stems from its interconnectedness; bestowed upon it by a compassionate Creator, this sanctity surpasses our capacity for comprehension (Mary Beth Ingham 2011, 184). This does not imply that the hierarchy of creation is entirely flattened, with worms and blades of grass possessing equal value and dignity alongside human beings. Instead, what the Subtle Doctor contends is that Whether a particular stone is useful to me is irrelevant when considering its inherent value (Daniel P. Horan 2018, 1063).

Conclusion

Fundamentally, the Franciscan ethos serves as both a critique and a complement to Aquinas’ thought, which views animals and the non-human universe primarily in terms of their utility to humans or beings above them (Mary A. Ashley 2018). Aquinas perceives a variety of formal distinctions within the created world. These forms, whether pertaining to humans or nonhumans, are inherently good. However, since “formal distinction inherently implies

inequality,” the diversity within creation also implies a hierarchy of beings, where some are deemed more perfect than others. Nonhuman animals exist for the benefit of the entire human community, encompassing both the present generation and those to come in the future (Ryan Patrick McLaughlin 2012, 70). This hierarchical view is founded on his categorization of life forms into three types of souls: vegetative, sensitive, and rational, with humans possessing the rational soul, making them superior due to their capacity for reason and prudence. This hierarchy implies that less perfect beings exist to serve more perfect ones.

While animals can exhibit practical wisdom and act on inner judgment, their abilities are instinctive and limited compared to humans’ comprehensive cleverness and abstract reasoning. Aquinas emphasizes that human cognition and rationality are distinct and superior, reflecting God’s image more profoundly. This unique human capacity for abstract thought and contemplation of the highest good sets humans apart. Although acknowledging shared traits between humans and animals, like memory and imagination, Aquinas maintains that human cognition operates at a higher level. Despite recognizing certain animal capacities, Aquinas insists that their primary purpose is to serve humans, a view criticized for justifying anthropocentrism and exploitation.

The Thomistic view on creation has significantly influenced the perspective of the Catechism of the Catholic Church on creation. According to the Catechism, animals, alongside plants and other non-living entities, are naturally intended for the collective welfare of humanity across time. However, the utilization of animal resources must be accompanied by adherence to moral principles. While humanity has been granted dominion over non-human beings by the Creator, this authority is not absolute; it is tempered by considerations for the well-being of others, including future generations (*The Catechism of the Catholic Church*, no. 2415). It necessitates a reverential regard for the wholeness of creation. Hence, it is deemed permissible to utilize

non-human animals for purposes such as sustenance, clothing, and scientific experimentation, provided that such actions contribute to the benefit of both present and future human societies (Ibid., no. 2417).

Aquinas believes that God designed these creatures for human use, allowing their use as long as it is not excessively cruel. This is because cruelty to animals negatively affects a person's moral character, increasing their likelihood of committing sin (Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I-II q.102, a. 6). In harmony with this perspective, in his call for universal communion and fraternity that excludes nothing and no one, Francis warns that our indifference and cruelty toward any creature will eventually manifest in our treatment of human beings (Francis 2015, no. 92).

The Thomistic philosophy of creation is not the only perspective Francis holds on animal cruelty. Pope Francis affirms the intrinsic value of each creature, which must be cherished with love and respect (Ibid., nos. 33 and 42). Creation holds value both as a whole and in its individual components, with ecosystems, species, and organisms possessing intrinsic worth (Ibid., nos. 221, 140, 33). Referencing Matthew 6:26 and Luke 12:6, he underscores the importance of every creature in God's eyes (Ibid., nos. 221, 240). This shift is rooted in the divine love for all creation, prioritizing their quality of existence over their utility (Ibid., no. 69). He relates the maternal love and sorrow of the Mother of Jesus, who grieved over His death and now grieves for the suffering of the poor and all creatures, highlighting their intrinsic value (Ibid., nos. 76 and 241).

Benedict XVI initiated this emphasis on the intrinsic value of creatures, evident in his characterization of the Sabbath as reflecting the "freedom and equality of all God's creatures" (Benedict XVI 2007; 2008). Published just before Benedict's term, the Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church asserted the unique value of humanity as willed by God (Pontifical Council for Justice and Peace, *Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the*

Church, no. 133). In his 2010 World Day of Peace message, Pope Benedict warns against diminishing the Church's traditional view of human superiority in creation. He argues that advocating an egalitarian vision of the "dignity" of all living creatures can undermine the distinctiveness and superior role of humans (Benedict XVI 2010). Accordingly despite Francis asserting that non-human animals are not mere "resources" and condemning a tyrannical anthropocentrism, he also contends that humans possess a uniqueness beyond the evolution of other systems (Kevin J. O'Brien 2019, 9f). *Laudato si'* recognizes humans as unique beings capable of engaging in an I-Thou dialogue with God and fellow-humans (Francis 2015, nos. 119 & 125). According to Pope Francis, such a vision fosters universal solidarity and deep communion with nature (Ibid., nos. 14, 85 & 91), as exemplified by Saint Francis of Assisi, who regarded all creatures as siblings (Ibid., nos. 11, 66).

While affirming the special dignity of humans above other creatures (Ibid., no. 119) and stating that an adequate anthropology is essential for ecology, thereby rejecting biocentrism (Ibid., no. 118), Francis condemns a tyrannical anthropocentrism that is indifferent to other creatures (Ibid., no. 68). In *Laudato si'*, the relationship between humans and non-human animals is addressed by upholding the uniqueness of humans, which distinguishes us from the rest of creation. This uniqueness includes the capacity for reason, abstract thought, invention, and art (Ibid., nos. 81 and 90). Human intervention on plants and non-human animals is allowed when it concerns the necessities of human life, but it is only morally acceptable if it stays within reasonable limits and contributes to caring for or saving human lives (Ibid., no. 130). Disapproval is expressed when there is more enthusiasm for protecting animal species than for defending human dignity (Ibid., nos. 81-92). While we should be concerned about the irresponsible treatment of other beings, we are called to be "particularly indignant" at the severe inequalities in society (Ibid., no. 90). Since Francis acknowledges the unique value and role of humans in creation, it is understandable

that the loss of human culture is considered more serious than the loss of plant or animal species (Ibid., no. 145).

The influence of the Franciscan tradition is explicitly visible in Pope Francis' understanding of the relationship between humans and non-human creation. Francis of Assisi advocates his reverence for the natural world, which is eloquently expressed in his "Cantic of the Sun." Here, Francis portrays creation as a familial network, urging a shift from a utilitarian view to recognizing the inherent worth of all creation, reflecting God's majesty.

This approach of the Seraphic father for an intrinsic appreciation of creatures has been recognized as a genuine Christian response to creation. Bonaventure extends this by highlighting Francis' *pietas*, a virtue traditionally linked to familial duty, now encompassing all of creation. He exemplifies how nonhuman creatures exhibit a kinship with humanity and a sense of agency, reflecting Francis' holistic approach to creation. Bonaventure highlights narratives of Francis' interactions with various animals to illustrate their agency. Bonaventure delineates three levels within creation: vestige, image, and likeness. All creation bears a vestige of the divine, but humans uniquely reflect God's image through cognitive capacity and moral affinity. Despite maintaining a hierarchical view, Bonaventure acknowledges the interconnectedness and unity of all creation, each part bearing a familial resemblance to the Creator.

Building on this, John Duns Scotus argues for the intrinsic dignity and value of each element of creation, emphasizing the principle of individuation or *haecceitas*. This unique "thisness" of every created being signifies its inherent worth, known only to God. Scotus' perspective, contrasting with Aquinas' more instrumental view, suggests that creation possesses an inherent light. However, this does not imply a completely leveled hierarchy in creation, suggesting that non-human creatures are as valuable as humans. Instead, it suggests that the utility of a particular thing to humans

does not determine its intrinsic worth. Thus, Saint Francis and scholars inspired by him articulate a vision where all creation has intrinsic value and interconnectedness, with humans occupying a unique position due to their cognitive and moral capacities, as articulated clearly in Pope Francis' teachings.

The unique anthropocentrism presented by Pope Francis, influenced by his patron Francis of Assisi and the scholars inspired by the Seraphic Father, corresponds very well with two dominant approaches in ecology. First it corresponds with the Self-realization approach of deep ecology, where nature gains intrinsic value as humans striving for self-realization become one with it. According to this perspective, if the self is intrinsically valuable and one with nature, it's rational for individuals to act in the best interest of nature (Eugene C. Hargrove 1992, 194).

Second, it corresponds with the theory which argues that the flourishing of numerous other living beings should be promoted because they contribute to our own flourishing. This approach is consistent with an ethic in which we value items in the natural world for their intrinsic worth, not merely as external means to fulfill our own desires. A truly fulfilling human life entails an awareness of and practical concern for the well-being of entities in the non-human realm. Consequently, an individual who engages in acts of environmental destruction exhibits a failure to understand what constitutes the best life for a human, as it disregards the value of non-human entities. By recognizing and promoting natural goods as valuable in themselves, we enrich the human experience and contribute to human flourishing (John O'Neill 1992, 132f).

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¹ Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XIX, 1a2ae, q. 24, a. 4. Thomas Aquinas acknowledged the presence of hope and despair in animals, attributing their instinct to a divine intellect capable of foreseeing the future. (Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* XXI, 1a2ae, Q. 40, a. 3).

² Biblical references are from the New Revised Standard Version Catholic Edition.



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Epistemology of Hope and the Francis Effect

Clement J Santhanam

Abstract

This article explores the epistemology of hope as a crucial category in philosophy and theology, focusing on its rational, trans-rational, and eschatological dimensions. Drawing on the insights of Kant, Marcel, Bloch, and Moltmann, the article highlights how hope mediates the human relation to future certainties, balancing reason, imagination, and faith. In dialogue with contemporary challenges such as the post-truth condition, the article argues that hope is neither reducible to blind optimism nor sterile rationalism. However, it constitutes a mode of cognition and orientation that sustains human meaning and ethical action. The climactic pastoral vision of Pope Francis situates hope as both a gift and a responsibility: a force of renewal that grounds human life in trust in God, solidarity with others, and active commitment to justice.

Introduction

Hope has long been recognised as an indispensable, though elusive, category in philosophy, theology, and human experience. Unlike simple optimism, which presumes positive outcomes irrespective of circumstances, hope extends beyond a mere mental attitude. It engages the human person cognitively, ethically, and spiritually, integrating desire, belief, and trust in relation to the future. At once rational and trans-rational, individual and communal, secular and